

BUSINESS ANALYSIS DOCUMENT

CafeBook — Business Opportunity & Growth Strategy

Market Analysis · Competitive Landscape · Revenue Model · Scale Roadmap



Product: Cafe Seat Booking Platform **Stage:** Built & Working (Single Cafe) **Date:** May 2026 **Version:** 1.0

1 Executive Summary

The one-line pitch: CafeBook is a simple, affordable seat reservation platform built specifically for cafes — the market that every major competitor has ignored in favour of fine-dining restaurants.

The Problem

- Most cafes still take bookings by phone or walk-in only
- No-shows cost cafes revenue daily with no warning
- Customers arrive to find no seats — and leave
- Staff waste time on phone reservation calls
- No data on busy times, popular zones, cancellations

The Solution CafeBook Provides

- Customers self-book online — no phone call needed
- Choose seating zone (window, outdoor, private nook)
- Admin dashboard to manage all bookings in real time
- Instant status updates: Pending → Confirmed → Complete
- Track bookings, no-shows, and table availability

2 Market Opportunity

700K+

Cafes & coffee shops worldwide

80%

Still use phone or walk-in only

£4.2B

Global restaurant booking market (2025)

Why Now?

- **Post-COVID shift:** Customers now expect to book ahead — reservation culture grew strongly after 2021
- **Digital expectations:** If a cafe has no online booking, younger customers simply choose one that does
- **Cost pressure on cafes:** Owners need tools to reduce no-shows and maximise every seat — margins are tight
- **Niche is underserved:** Big reservation platforms focused on restaurants and hotels — indie cafes were left behind

3 Competitive Landscape

Competitor	Target Market	Monthly Cost	Zone Selection	Cafe-Friendly?
OpenTable	Mid-high end restaurants	£250–£550	No	No — too expensive & complex
Resy	Upscale dining, US-focused	£200–£450	No	No — wrong market segment
SevenRooms	Enterprise / hotel chains	£400+ (call for price)	Partial	No — enterprise only
ResDiary	UK restaurants & pubs	£99–£199	No	Partial — still restaurant-focused
Google Reserve	Any business	Free	No	Basic only — no seat selection
CafeBook	Independent cafes	£25–£60	Yes — 6 zones	Built for cafes

The key gap: No competitor lets the customer choose *where* they sit — only *when*. CafeBook's zone-based booking is a genuine differentiator. A remote worker wants the window seat. A couple wants the private nook. Parents want the accessible table. That choice matters and nobody else offers it simply.

4 Current Strengths & What's Missing

✓ What CafeBook Already Does Well

- Zone-aware seat selection — unique in the market
- Real-time availability — no double-booking possible
- Clean admin dashboard with booking stats
- Accessibility flag on tables — inclusive design
- Simple one-click start — no complex setup
- Secure JWT login — professional-grade auth
- Status workflow — Pending → Confirmed → Completed

X What's Missing to Be Commercially Viable

- No email confirmation after booking
- No SMS reminder before visit
- No payment or deposit collection
- No password reset feature
- No cloud hosting — runs on one local machine only
- No analytics charts (peak hours, no-show rate)
- No multi-cafe / multi-location support
- No mobile app or PWA

5 Growth Roadmap

NOW	3 MONTHS	6 MONTHS	12 MONTHS
Phase 1 — Live Product • Single cafe • Zone booking • Admin dashboard • Secure login • Working & stable	Phase 2 — Sellable • Email confirmations • SMS reminders • Password reset • Cloud hosting • Stripe deposits	Phase 3 — Scalable • Multi-cafe support • Analytics dashboard • Waitlist feature • QR code check-in • Subscription billing	Phase 4 — Platform • Chain management • Loyalty programme • POS integration • Mobile app • API marketplace

Smartest first move: Give it free to one real local cafe. Watch how the staff actually use the admin panel. Watch what customers complain about. That real-world feedback is worth more than any feature you could add right now — and it gives you a live case study to show the next cafe.

6 Revenue Model

Starter £25 / month	Pro POPULAR £60 / month	Chain £150 / month
✓ 1 cafe location ✓ Up to 100 bookings/month ✓ Email confirmations ✓ Basic admin dashboard ✓ Email support	✓ 1 cafe location ✓ Unlimited bookings ✓ Email + SMS reminders ✓ Analytics & reports ✓ Stripe deposit collection ✓ Priority support	✓ Up to 10 locations ✓ Unlimited bookings ✓ All Pro features ✓ White-label branding ✓ Loyalty programme ✓ Dedicated support

Revenue Projection (Conservative)

- 10 cafes on Starter (£25): £250/month → £3,000/year
- 20 cafes on Pro (£60): £1,200/month → £14,400/year
- 3 chains on Chain (£150): £450/month → £5,400/year

- **Total at 33 customers:** ~£22,800/year — enough to fund further development
- **At 200 cafes on Pro:** £12,000/month — this is a viable business

7 What to Build Next — Implementation Plan

Feature	Why It Matters	How to Build It	Effort
Email Confirmations	Customers expect a confirmation email — without it, they don't trust the booking	Add SendGrid or Nodemailer to the Spring Boot backend. Send email on booking creation and status change.	2–3 days
SMS Reminders	Reduces no-shows by ~30%. The single biggest way to recover lost revenue for cafes.	Integrate Twilio API. Send automated reminder 24 hours before booking time.	2–3 days
Password Reset	Without this, locked-out users abandon the platform	Send a time-limited reset link to email. Store a reset token in the database with expiry.	1–2 days
Cloud Hosting	Currently runs on one local machine — no real cafe can use it remotely	Deploy to Railway, Render, or AWS. Replace H2 with PostgreSQL. Takes the app from local to internet-accessible.	3–5 days
Stripe Deposits	Taking even a £2 deposit eliminates most no-shows — customers have skin in the game	Add Stripe Checkout to the booking form. Store payment intent ID on the booking record.	3–4 days
Analytics Dashboard	Data is what convinces cafe owners to pay for a subscription. "Your peak hour is 11am Saturday" is valuable insight.	Add a charts page in admin using Chart.js. Query existing booking data for peak hours, zone popularity, no-show rate, weekly trends.	4–5 days
Multi-Cafe Support	Without this, you can only ever have one customer. This is the unlock for scale.	Add a Cafe entity. Every table, booking, and zone belongs to a cafe. Each admin sees only their cafe's data.	1–2 weeks
Real-Time Availability	Two users could book the same table simultaneously — rare but damaging when it happens	Add WebSocket support or database-level locking. Show live "just booked" updates on the booking page.	1 week

8 Risks & How to Handle Them

Risk	Level	Why It Matters	How to Reduce It
Cafe owners don't change habits	HIGH	Phone/walk-in is familiar — convincing owners to switch requires effort and proof	Offer a free trial. Show them one month of data proving fewer no-shows. Let results do the selling.
A competitor copies the cafe niche	MEDIUM	OpenTable or Resy could add an affordable cafe tier	Move fast. Build loyalty with early customers. Add features big platforms won't bother with (loyalty stamps, zone preference memory).
Technical — data loss	MEDIUM	H2 database is a local file — if the machine fails, all bookings are lost	Move to cloud PostgreSQL with daily backups before taking paying customers.
No-shows still happen	MEDIUM	Booking system alone doesn't eliminate no-shows — cafes need deposits or reminders	Build SMS reminders and optional deposits in Phase 2. Show no-show reduction data to prove value.
Small customer base	LOW	Getting the first 20 cafes signed up is the hardest part	Start local. Visit cafes in person. Offer free setup. First customers become case studies and referrals.

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Bottom Line

What's Strong

- Real gap in the market
- Zone selection is unique
- Clean, working codebase
- Low cost to run
- Affordable for small cafes

What to Do First

- Add email confirmations
- Deploy to the cloud
- Give to one real cafe free
- Collect real feedback
- Then charge for it

Long-Term Vision

- Multi-cafe SaaS platform
- Analytics that cafes love
- Loyalty + POS integration
- The "Shopify for cafes"
- Acquirable by larger players

The product is built. The code works. The gap is real. The next step is not more features — it is getting one real cafe to use it, watching what breaks, and fixing that. Every successful software business started the same way: one real customer, real feedback, real improvement.